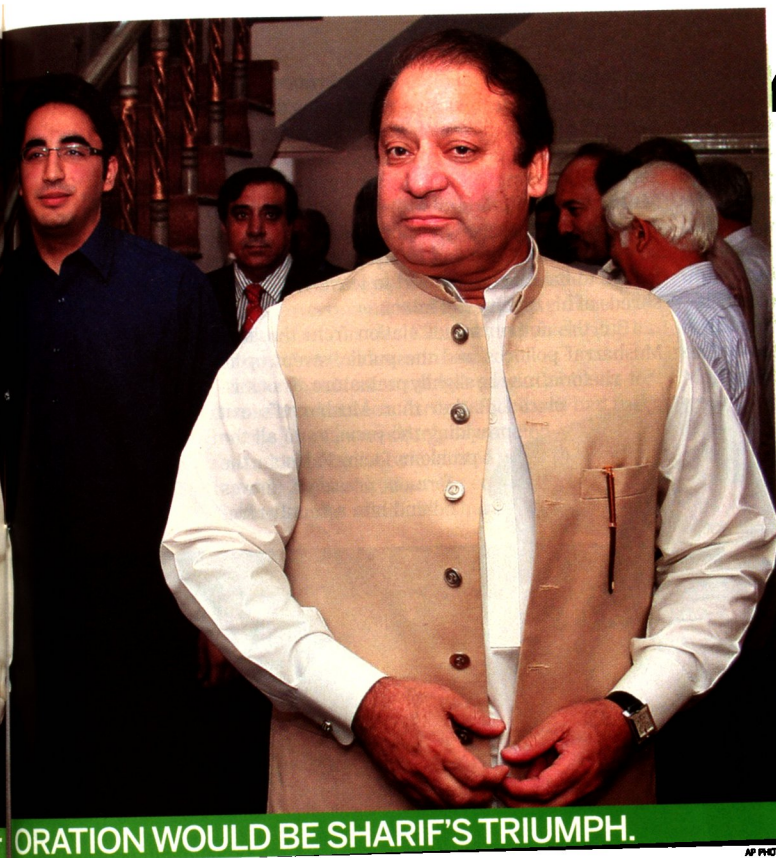




“We were prepared for the worst. I expected Musharraf to put up a fight but he has run away.”

the judges would be reinstated immediately. It would end the uncertainty which has affected governance. And if the coalition breaks over this, uncertainties will heighten.

Q. Are you okay with Asif Zardari becoming the President?

A. We have not demanded this slot for our own party. Any President should be above party politics and not be partisan. I feel that a man of national consensus and stature who commands the confidence of the people should be the President.

Q. What will be the impact of Musharraf's exit?

A. Democracy is coming back in the country. There will be no future Musharrafs and no future military interventions. That's why we are saying he should be accountable for his actions. Such people should pay for what they have done to prevent future generals from taking power again.

Q. India's concern is that with political instability and Musharraf's exit, the war on terror is facing a setback.

A. There is no room for extremism in Pakistan. Of course, we are aware of the conscious concern of the international community and our own people. To deal with the issue, we need to have a national policy formulated by the Parliament. Previously it was only one man who was calling the shots.

Q. India's relations with Pakistan are under pressure after the Kabul bombing and terror attacks on cities.

A. Apart from allegations and counter-allegations we must sit down and listen to each others concerns and address them in all seriousness. If India does have concrete evidence, we should look at it.

INTERVIEW | NAWAZ SHARIF

“Musharraf should stand trial for his actions”

Nawaz Sharif, chief of the Pakistan Muslim League (Nawaz) and a former prime minister, spoke to Managing Editor RAJ CHENGAPPA, a day after Musharraf's resignation. Excerpts:

Q. Did you expect Musharraf to resign without a fight?

A. We were prepared for the worst. I expected him to put up some fight but he has run away.

Q. What forced him to resign?

A. The fear of impeachment and the strong chargesheet that we put up. He was going to find it difficult to answer it and once the chargesheet was issued, it would have been a stigma forever. Musharraf realised

that he was on a weak wicket.

Q. Is there a deal to give Musharraf amnesty?

A. We are not wheeler dealers. We think that he owes an answer to the people of this country. He should be held accountable for what he has done—not what he has done to Nawaz Sharif, but to the country. I am not trying to settle personal scores.

Q. So no exile for Musharraf?

A. We should finally say goodbye to the policy of exiles.

Q. The reinstatement of judges has become a contentious issue.

A. There are some bumps. Our point is that Zardari should honour his commitment in writing which is that